

Deborah Tannen writes that critics often spend too much time finding faults in others' work when they could instead build on it. Her point helps reframe what academic argument can be. Rather than a battle with winners and losers, scholarly writing can be a conversation in which thinkers build on each other's ideas. This essay follows that model by putting two texts in conversation: Albert Camus's "The Myth of Sisyphus" and the Metropolitan Museum's "Afrofuturism in the Stacks." Both navigate how people search for meaning in systems that deny it.

Boots Riley's film *Sorry to Bother You* serves as the exhibit for this discussion. The film is a surreal story about race, capitalism, and resistance. It captures the absurd struggle for purpose that Camus describes, while also embodying the Afrofuturist belief that imagination can lead to freedom. By setting Camus and Afrofuturism in dialogue, this essay argues that *Sorry to Bother You* transforms the absurd idea of meaningless struggle into a vision of collective liberation. Where Camus imagines an individual who accepts futility, Riley imagines a community that resists it together.

Camus's "The Myth of Sisyphus" opens with a question: if life has no meaning, should we continue living? He calls this "the only truly serious philosophical problem." His answer is yes. Although the universe offers no purpose or logic, humans still crave understanding. The gap between this desire and the world's silence creates what he calls "the absurd." In his words, "the struggle itself toward the heights is enough to fill a man's heart. One must imagine Sisyphus happy." For Camus, meaning comes not from finding answers but from facing futility with awareness and defiance.

Afrofuturism begins from a different history. According to “Afrofuturism in the Stacks,” this creative movement uses science fiction, art, and history to “reimagine the past and project liberated futures for Black existence.” It goes against centuries of oppression by imagining new worlds where Black people thrive. Afrofuturism connects historical pain to imagination. It really insists that even in the face of dehumanization, Black creativity can build new realities.

While Camus writes from the experience of European existential despair, Afrofuturism grows from collective survival against racial injustice. Yet both of them wrestle with the same issue: how to live meaningfully in an unfree world. Absurdism confronts futility through personal rebellion. Afrofuturism confronts it through community and imagination. Riley’s *Sorry to Bother You* stages their meeting.

At first, *Sorry to Bother You* looks like a casual story about ambition. Cassius “Cash” Green, a young Black man in Oakland, takes a telemarketing job at RegalView. He quickly learns that the only way to succeed is to use his “white voice,” an overdubbed sound that turns him into someone who sounds cheerful and wealthy. His sales numbers soar. Yet every success pushes him further from himself.

From an absurdist perspective, Cash’s story mirrors Sisyphus’s endless labor. He seeks purpose through work, but the system that rewards him is meaningless. The “white voice” scene captures this. When Cash speaks through that false voice, he becomes alien to himself. Camus calls this moment of separation the “divorce between man and his life.” The world continues, but it no longer makes sense.

The absurd grows darker as the film moves forward. The company WorryFree offers workers lifetime labor contracts that pretty much amount to modern slavery. Later, Cash learns that

WorryFree's CEO plans to transform workers into human-horse hybrids called equisapiens. The idea is both ridiculous and horrifying. Camus might describe this as the moment when logic turns back on itself. Capitalism's hunger for efficiency and profit reaches its absurd conclusion: literal dehumanization.

Camus writes that the absurd arises when reason confronts the unreasonable. Riley's film shows that this confrontation is not only philosophical but economic and racial. The absurd is built into the structure of modern labor. Cash's world makes no moral sense, yet it functions smoothly. His horror reflects the realization that he lives in a rational system that has lost all humanity.

Against this absurd world stands Detroit, Cash's girlfriend and an artist. She wears bold clothing and performs radical art that mixes pain and beauty. Her earrings display words like "Murder Murder Murder, Kill Kill Kill." In one performance, she recites poetry while audience members throw cell phones and balloons at her nearly nude body. Detroit uses her body and art to expose how Black suffering becomes a spectacle in capitalist culture.

According to "Afrofuturism in the Stacks," Afrofuturist art "creates spaces where Black identity is not confined by oppression but liberated through creativity." Detroit embodies that idea. She refuses to let capitalism or patriarchy define her. Her art transforms trauma into expression and possibility.

In this sense, Detroit can be seen as a new kind of Sisyphus. She recognizes absurdity but turns it into creation instead of despair. Camus's Sisyphus finds freedom in awareness. Detroit finds freedom in imagination. Her resistance is collective because it speaks to her community. Through her, Riley adds a dimension that Camus's essay lacks: rebellion as shared art, not solitary endurance.

When Camus writes, “To deal with an unfree world is to become so absolutely free that your very existence is an act of rebellion” he envisions a single person confronting the void. In *Sorry to Bother You*, that kind of solitary freedom is impossible. The forces of racism and capitalism are too systemic to face alone. The film argues that rebellion must be collective.

Cash begins as a man chasing individual success. By the film’s midpoint, he joins his coworkers in a strike against RegalView. At first he betrays them for promotion, but guilt draws him back. His journey shows the shift from Camus’s existential freedom to Afrofuturism’s communal liberation. The strike scenes transform abstract rebellion into real solidarity. The workers chant, sing, and link arms in defiance.

This convergence leads to a central claim: absurdism can reveal the futility of human systems, but Afrofuturism shows how imagination can turn that futility into change. Absurdism teaches awareness. Afrofuturism teaches invention. Together, they create a philosophy of collective struggle.

Cash’s eventual transformation into an equisapien deepens this point. Though the mutation is forced, it also symbolizes rebirth. The absurd becomes literal, but so does freedom. By the film’s end, the equisapiens revolt against their creators. The rebellion succeeds not because one hero finds meaning, but because many unite.

Riley fills his film with small absurd details that comment on modern life. The elevator to the executive floor, for example, requires a long password full of sexual jokes. It turns a basic machine into a ritual of humiliation. This shows how corporate environments often disguise

domination as fun. Camus writes that the absurd can be found in “the mechanical lives of men,” when routines lose purpose but continue anyway. The elevator sequence captures that perfectly.

The “white voice” also shows how language itself becomes absurd. When Cash uses it, he can speak fluently but says nothing real. Communication turns into performance. The customers hear comfort, not truth. This reflects what Camus calls “the silence of the world.” Meaning disappears even as words multiply.

Afrofuturist imagery counters this silence. Detroit’s fashion blends African prints with futuristic colors. Her earrings and hairstyles recall both ancient art and science fiction. Afrofuturism “reclaims ancestral symbols through futuristic design.” Riley uses costume and color to suggest continuity between past and future.

The equisapiens sequence also fits this pattern. It takes the grotesque legacy of slavery and turns it into a speculative vision. The horse-people are products of exploitation, yet they become the film’s agents of change. Afrofuturist scholar Alondra Nelson describes this transformation as “the future imagined through the scars of the past.” Riley visualizes that process in motion.

Absurdism gives the film its structure, while Afrofuturism fills it with hope. The first exposes the system’s madness. The second imagines what comes after.

Riley does not present imagination as a perfect solution. He shows how even rebellion can be absorbed by capitalism. When Cash exposes WorryFree’s crimes, his story becomes viral entertainment. People watch the video of equisapiens in horror, but stock prices rise anyway. The system turns resistance into profit.

Camus warns of this danger in *The Rebel*. He writes that revolutions can betray themselves when they become institutionalized or seek total control. Similarly, Afrofuturism can risk turning liberation into aesthetics without substance. Riley's film recognizes that tension.

Cash's fame illustrates how rebellion can become spectacle. His moral awakening does not free him immediately. He must continue fighting, even after being celebrated as a hero. The final uprising reminds viewers that revolution is not a single event but a continuous process. Like Sisyphus pushing the boulder, the workers must rise again and again. Like Afrofuturist artists, they must keep imagining futures no one has seen.

Bringing Camus and Afrofuturism together changes how we think about resistance. Camus's absurdism emerged in the 1940s, when Europe faced war and disillusionment. Afrofuturism grew from the Black diaspora's ongoing fight against racial and economic oppression. Their contexts differ, but their insights connect. Both reject despair and insist on creative survival.

In *Sorry to Bother You*, Riley shows that the absurd is not only philosophical but political. The systems that make life meaningless are built by human power. Therefore, they can also be challenged. This shift from individual to collective rebellion has real stakes. It reframes freedom as something that must be shared to be real.

For readers and viewers, this synthesis matters because it links thought to action. Camus teaches awareness of absurdity. Afrofuturism teaches creation beyond it. Riley turns both lessons into a story about labor, art, and solidarity. His film invites us to imagine Sisyphus not alone on a mountain but among others pushing together.

Boots Riley's *Sorry to Bother You* can be read as a modern rewriting of Camus's myth. Instead of a lone man pushing a rock, we see a group of workers fighting for dignity in a world that mocks them. Instead of endless repetition, we see transformation through imagination.

Camus ends his essay by telling us that we must imagine Sisyphus happy. Riley goes further. He asks us to imagine Sisyphus organized, creative, and free. The absurd condition remains, but its meaning changes. If struggle is inevitable, it can still lead to connection.

Afrofuturism gives the absurd a new direction. It turns endless labor into a platform for dreaming. It insists that even within systems of exploitation, people can imagine new worlds and bring them into being. In that sense, *Sorry to Bother You* completes Camus's vision by expanding it.

Riley's film shows that rebellion is not just survival. It's the creation of something worth surviving for. The absurd may define the human condition, but imagination defines the human response. The film closes with the *equisapiens* storming *WorryFree* headquarters. It's a strange and powerful image.